not launched its current product, the team never would have learned what it needed to know to pivot. In fact, the experience taught them something essential about their vision. As Andy says, "What we really wanted to change was not who manages the money but who has access to the best possible talent. We'd originally thought we'd need to build a significant business with amateur managers to get professionals to come on board, but fortunately it turns out that wasn't necessary."

The company pivoted, abandoning the gaming customers altogether and focusing on providing a service that allowed customers to invest with professional managers. On the surface, the pivot seems quite dramatic in that the company changed its positioning, its name, and its partner strategy. It even jettisoned a large proportion of the features it had built. But at its core, a surprising amount stayed the same. The most valuable work the company had done was building technology to evaluate managers' effectiveness, and this became the kernel around which the new business was built. This is also common with pivots; it is not necessary to throw out everything that came before and start over. Instead, it's about repurposing what has been built and what has been learned to find a more positive direction.

Today, Wealthfront is prospering as a result of its pivot, with over $180 million invested on the platform and more than forty professional managers.[3] It recently was named one of Fast Company's ten most innovative companies in finance.[4] The company continues to operate with agility, scaling in line with the growth principles outlined in Chapter 12. Wealthfront is also a leading advocate of the development technique known as continuous deployment, which we'll discuss in Chapter 9.

FAILURE TO PIVOT

The decision to pivot is so difficult that many companies fail to make it. I wish I could say that every time I was confronted with the need to pivot, I handled it well, but this is far from true. I